

BEFORE YOU LAND™

The Ultimate International Student Survival Guide

Everything nobody tells you about moving to America — documents, money, credit, housing, healthcare, classrooms, work rules, and how to actually feel at home.



Created by **Nii Obodai** × **Travedconsult.com**

FLAGSHIP EDITION · 19 CHAPTERS

FOR INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS IN THE U.S.

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Read this first

Somewhere right now there's a student holding an admission letter, staring at a suitcase, wondering how a whole life fits into 46 kilograms. This guide was written for that student — because I was that student.

Nobody hands you a manual when you move countries. You learn that your visa and your status are two different things by almost losing one of them. You learn what a credit score is when a landlord rejects you for not having one. You learn what "deductible" means from a bill you didn't expect. Every international student before you has paid tuition twice: once to their school, and once to their mistakes.

This guide is the second tuition, refunded. It's organized the way your first year actually unfolds: what to handle **before you fly**, what to do in your **first 30 days**, how to **live smart** on a student budget, how the **rules about school, work, and taxes** really work, and how to go from surviving to **actually thriving**.

You don't need to read it cover to cover tonight. Read Part I before you fly. Keep the rest on your phone and open the chapter you need, when you need it. That's what it's for.

You're not just moving to study. You're building a life. Let's make sure it starts on solid ground.

— Nii Obodai

Creator, *Before You Land*™ · Co-created with [Travedconsult.com](https://travedconsult.com)

BEFORE WE START — ONE HONEST NOTE

Immigration and visa rules are serious and they change. This guide explains how things generally work so nothing surprises you, but it is not legal advice. For anything touching your visa status — work, transfers, travel, deadlines — your school's **Designated School Official (DSO)** at the international student office is your official source, and their advice beats anything in any book, including this one.

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Chapter 1 — The documents that run your life

For your first years in America, you are, administratively speaking, a small stack of papers. Guard the stack.

The core four

Document	What it actually is
Passport	Your identity. Must generally stay valid at least six months beyond your stay. Renew early — never let it expire while abroad.
Visa stamp	The sticker in your passport. It's an <i>entry ticket</i> — it lets you knock on America's door. It can even expire while you're inside the U.S. and that's usually fine, as long as your status is intact.
I-20 (or DS-2019)	Your school's certificate of eligibility. This is the document that defines your <i>status</i> . You'll need it to enter the country, get an SSN, and sometimes to re-enter after travel. Treat it like a second passport.
I-94 record	The electronic record created each time you enter. It says how long you're allowed to stay — for students, usually "D/S" (duration of status). Check it online after every entry and make sure it says F-1, D/S.

THE DISTINCTION THAT SAVES CAREERS

Visa ≠ status. Your *visa* gets you in the door; your *status* keeps you legally inside. Status is maintained by being a full-time student, not working illegally, keeping your I-20 valid, and following the rules. An expired visa stamp is an inconvenience the next time you travel. A violated status is an emergency. Know which is which.

Your DSO: the most important stranger in your life

Every school has a **Designated School Official** — usually in the international student office. They manage your SEVIS record, sign your I-20 for travel, authorize your work permissions, and answer status questions. Learn their name, their office hours, and their email before you land. When in doubt about anything immigration-related, ask them first. It's free, it's official, and it's their whole job.

The travel folder rule

- **Originals in your carry-on, on your body:** passport, I-20, SEVIS fee receipt, admission letter, proof of funds, insurance card, prescriptions.
- **Digital copies in cloud storage** you can reach from any device.
- **One photocopy set in your checked bag**, separate from the originals.

NEVER

Never pack your passport or I-20 in checked luggage. If your bag flies to the wrong continent — and bags do — you cannot enter the country on a boarding pass and good intentions.

PART I • BEFORE YOU FLY

Chapter 2 — Surviving the port of entry

The scariest part of the journey is a five-minute conversation. Here's exactly how it goes.

When you land, you'll queue for **U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP)**. An officer will check your passport, visa, and I-20, maybe take fingerprints and a photo, and ask a few questions. This is routine screening, not an interrogation. They talk to thousands of students every August.

The questions, and how to answer

They ask	You say
"What's the purpose of your visit?"	"I'm starting my master's/bachelor's at [school]." Simple, direct, done.
"What will you study?"	Your program name. You don't need to defend your life choices.
"Where will you stay?"	Your dorm or address. Have it written down.
"How will you pay for school?"	Scholarship, family sponsorship, savings — whatever's true and matches your I-20.

- **Answer honestly and briefly.** Volunteering extra information rarely helps and sometimes confuses things.
- **Never joke** about visas, working illegally, or staying forever. Border officers are professionally immune to comedy.
- **Have your documents in hand** before you reach the desk, not buried in a backpack.

If you're sent to secondary inspection

Sometimes students get directed to a separate waiting room for extra checks — often for something as small as a system mismatch or a common name. It can take an hour or more. It is usually not a sign of trouble. Stay calm, answer questions, and don't sign anything you don't understand. If your pickup is waiting, they'll wait; missing a connecting flight is fixable.

CONNECTING FLIGHTS

You clear immigration at your *first* U.S. airport, even if your final stop is elsewhere — and you usually collect and re-check your bag there too. Leave at least three hours between an international arrival and a domestic connection. Two hours is a prayer, not a plan.

After you clear

- ☐ Within a few days, look up your **I-94 record** on the official CBP website and confirm it shows F-1 and "D/S". Screenshot it.
- ☐ Report any errors on your I-94 or entry stamp to your DSO immediately — small errors are easy to fix early and painful to fix later.

PART I • BEFORE YOU FLY

Chapter 3 — Your first-month money plan

The gap between landing and having a working U.S. bank account is where budgets go to die. Plan the bridge.

The three-layer money strategy

- 1 Cash for week one.** Carry enough U.S. dollars for transport, food, a SIM card, and small surprises — mostly in twenties and smaller. (If you carry more than \$10,000 in cash or equivalents, you must declare it at customs. It's legal; hiding it is not.)
- 2 An international card that works in the U.S.** A Visa or Mastercard from home — debit or credit — is your backup for bigger purchases and emergencies until your U.S. account opens. Confirm foreign transaction fees with your home bank so you're not surprised.
- 3 A transfer plan for the big money.** Tuition and rent money should move through official channels: wire transfer, your school's payment portal, or a reputable transfer service. Compare exchange rates and fees — they differ more than you'd think.

What your first month actually costs

Beyond tuition and rent, budget for the invisible start-up costs almost everyone forgets:

- Bedding, kitchen basics, toiletries, a lamp — the "empty room tax" of moving anywhere
- Security deposit (often equal to a month's rent) if renting off-campus
- Phone plan setup, transit card, first grocery run (the first one is always the biggest)
- Textbooks and course materials — before you buy new, check rentals, used copies, digital versions, and the library

REAL TALK

Do not arrive with all your money in cash "to be safe." Students lose envelopes, and dorms have many keys. Carry a sensible amount, keep the rest in a bank at home you can transfer from, and make opening a U.S. account a first-week mission — Chapter 5 shows you how, even without an SSN.

PART II · YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS

Chapter 4 — The Big Five: your first-week missions

Everything in your first month gets easier if you complete five missions in roughly this order. Your bonus *First 30 Days Planner* turns these into a day-by-day plan.

- 1 Get connected (Day 1–2).** A U.S. phone number unlocks everything else — banks, campus systems, deliveries, two-factor codes. Prepaid and student-friendly carriers will get you running the day you land; you can optimize plans later.
- 2 Check in with your DSO (Week 1 — deadline!).** Report to the international student office and complete SEVIS registration. This tells the system you actually arrived and keeps your F-1 status active. Your school gives you a deadline; treat it as sacred.
- 3 Open a U.S. bank account (Week 1–2).** You do *not* need an SSN for this at most banks — Chapter 5 has the exact document list. Until this exists, you're paying foreign card fees on every coffee.
- 4 Set up your campus life (Week 1–2).** Student ID card, class registration confirmed, campus app installed, library card, and a walk of your actual class route before day one — buildings hide.
- 5 Establish your home base (Week 2–4).** Learn your neighborhood: grocery store, pharmacy, clinic, laundromat, transit stop. Buy the boring essentials. Cook one real meal. The moment your room stops feeling like a hotel, your brain calms down.

ORIENTATION IS NOT OPTIONAL

Go to every orientation event you're invited to, especially international student orientation. It's where you meet the people who become your first friends, learn the unwritten rules, and find out about free food with impressive precision. Nobody has ever regretted going. Many regret skipping.

PART II · YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS

Chapter 5 — Banking in America made simple

American banking is easy once someone explains the vocabulary and the traps. Consider them explained.

The two accounts

Account	What it's for
Checking	Daily life. Your debit card, rent payments, and paychecks live here. This is the one you open first.
Savings	Money you're not spending this month. Often opened alongside checking. Build a small emergency cushion here as soon as you can.

Opening an account without an SSN

Most major banks and many credit unions will open a student account with:

- ☐ Passport (with visa)
- ☐ I-20 and proof of enrollment (admission letter or student ID)
- ☐ Proof of local address — a lease, dorm assignment letter, or a letter from your school
- ☐ Some secondary ID if asked (national ID, home bank card)

If one branch tells you an SSN is required, that's often a staff-training issue, not policy — try another branch or another bank. Banks near universities handle international students constantly and know the drill. Many schools also partner with specific banks or credit unions and can point you to the smoothest option.

Choosing well: the questions to ask

- Is there a **monthly maintenance fee**, and is it waived for students?
- Are there **ATMs on or near campus**? Out-of-network ATM fees add up fast.
- Does the app support **Zelle**? It's how Americans split rent and dinner — instant, free, bank-to-bank.
- What are the **international wire fees** for receiving money from home?

THE OVERDRAFT TRAP

If you spend more than you have, some accounts "helpfully" let the payment go through — then charge you a fee of \$30 or more per incident. Ask the bank to **disable overdraft coverage** so your card simply declines instead. A declined card costs pride; overdraft fees cost money.

Vocabulary you'll actually use

Word	Meaning
Routing number	Identifies your bank — needed to receive transfers and paychecks.
Account number	Identifies your specific account. Routing + account = getting paid.
Direct deposit	Your paycheck going straight into your account. Employers will ask for a "voided check" or your two numbers above.
Statement	Monthly summary of your account. Also doubles as proof of address later.

PART II • YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS

Chapter 6 — Building credit from zero

In America, your credit score is a financial passport. You arrive without one — and that's fixable, starting this semester.

What credit actually is

A credit score (roughly 300–850) is a number that tells lenders, landlords, and sometimes even phone companies how reliably you repay borrowed money. No history means no score — and to the system, no score looks like risk. That's why newcomers get asked for bigger deposits, co-signers, or months of prepaid rent. The good news: the system doesn't care where you're from, only what you do next.

How scores are built

- **Payment history** — the big one. Pay every bill on time, every time. One missed payment can undo a year of good behavior.
- **Utilization** — how much of your credit limit you use. Keep it under about 30%; under 10% is even better. A \$500 limit means keeping the balance under \$150.
- **Age of accounts** — older is better, which is why you start now and never close your first card.
- **New applications** — each application dings you slightly. Apply deliberately, not enthusiastically.

Your realistic starter options

- 1 **A secured credit card.** You deposit a few hundred dollars as collateral; that becomes your limit. Use it lightly, pay in full monthly, and after some months of good behavior many banks upgrade you and return the deposit. This is the classic from-zero path.
- 2 **A student credit card.** Some issuers offer starter cards designed for students with no history — a few even market specifically to international students without an SSN. Ask your own bank first; an existing relationship helps.

- 3** **Becoming an authorized user** on a trusted person's card, if you have family in the U.S. — their good history can help seed yours.

The golden rules

- ☐ **Pay the full balance monthly.** Carrying a balance does not help your score; it only pays the bank interest.
- ☐ **Set up autopay** for at least the minimum, so a busy exam week never becomes a late payment.
- ☐ **Use the card for small routine things** — groceries, phone bill — not for money you don't have.
- ☐ **Never miss, never max, never close your oldest card.**

REAL TALK

A credit card in America is a reputation-building tool wearing the costume of free money. Students who treat it as reputation graduate with a 740 score, easy apartment approvals, and cheaper everything. Students who treat it as free money spend years paying 25% interest on pizzas they don't remember eating. Same card. Choose your story.

PART II • YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS

Chapter 7 — SSNs, state IDs, and proving you exist

Two small cards make American bureaucracy dramatically easier. Here's what you can get, and when.

The Social Security Number (SSN)

An SSN is a lifetime tax identification number. Here's what surprises most students: **you can't get one just for existing** — as an F-1 student you generally become eligible when you have authorized employment, like an on-campus job or approved CPT/OPT. The usual path:

- 1** Land a job offer (on-campus counts — library, dining hall, research assistant).
- 2** Get the supporting letters your school requires (your DSO and employer help with this).
- 3** Apply at a Social Security office with your passport, I-20, I-94, and job documentation.
- 4** The card arrives by mail. Memorize the number; store the card at home, not in your wallet.

No job yet? No SSN — and that's fine. You can bank, rent, get a phone, and build credit without one. Anyone who insists you "must" have an SSN for those things is wrong or trying something.

GUARD THE NUMBER

Your SSN is the master key to identity theft. Real institutions rarely ask for it by phone or email. No government agency will ever call demanding it, threatening arrest, or requesting gift cards — that's a scam with a script, aimed at international students specifically. Hang up. (More in Chapter 18.)

The state ID (or driver's license)

Carrying your passport everywhere is a bad habit waiting to become a bad day. Once you have a local address, visit your state's DMV/RMV to get a **state ID card** — or a driver's license if you'll drive (Chapter 11). Requirements vary by state but generally include your passport, I-20, I-94, and proofs of address. It becomes your everyday ID for age checks, domestic flights, and not panicking about your passport.

PART II · YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS

Chapter 8 — Housing, leases, and roommates

Your home determines your sleep, your budget, and half your happiness. Choose with your eyes open.

On-campus vs off-campus, honestly

	The trade
On-campus	Simpler: furnished, utilities included, no credit checks, walk to class, built-in community. Costs more per square meter and comes with rules. Excellent for year one.
Off-campus	Usually cheaper (especially shared), more freedom and space. But: leases, deposits, utility bills, furniture, commutes, and landlords who may want credit history you don't have yet. Better once you know the city.

Reading a lease like an adult

A lease is a binding contract, usually for 12 months. Before signing, know:

- ☐ **Total move-in cost** — first month, security deposit, sometimes last month and fees. Get the full number in writing.
- ☐ **What's included** — heat? water? electricity? internet? "Utilities not included" can add real money monthly, especially in winter.
- ☐ **The exit rules** — what breaking the lease costs, and whether you can sublet for summer.
- ☐ **Everyone on the lease?** If your name isn't on it, you have roommate privileges and zero legal protection.

On move-in day: photograph everything — walls, floors, appliances, existing damage — and email the photos to the landlord and yourself. That timestamped email is how you get your deposit back a year later.

THE SCAM CHECKLIST

Rental scams love international students because you're searching from another continent. Assume it's a scam if: the rent is suspiciously below market · they can't or won't show the unit (even by live video) · they pressure you to wire money or send gift cards to "hold" it · the "landlord" is conveniently abroad · they want money before any signed lease. Never send money for a place no one you trust has seen. Your school's off-campus housing office can sanity-check listings for free.

Roommates: the pre-nup conversation

Most roommate wars are fought over four things: cleaning, noise, guests, and shared costs. Have one honest conversation in week one — how you'll split supplies and utilities, quiet hours, dishes policy, guest expectations — and you'll skip 90% of the drama. Awkward for ten minutes; peaceful for twelve months.

PART II · YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS

Chapter 9 — Healthcare without the panic

American healthcare is famously expensive and genuinely confusing. Insurance plus knowing where to go solves most of it.

The vocabulary (learn these five words)

Word	Meaning
Premium	What you pay for the insurance itself (often bundled into your student fees).
Deductible	What you pay out of pocket each year before insurance starts covering most costs.
Copay	The fixed amount you pay per visit or prescription (e.g., \$25 to see a doctor).
In-network	Doctors and hospitals your plan has deals with. Staying in-network is dramatically cheaper.
Out-of-pocket max	The most you'd pay in a truly bad year — your worst-case ceiling. Know this number.

Where to go: the ladder

- 1 Campus health center** — your default for everyday illness, vaccines, and referrals. Low or no cost, used to students, start here.
- 2 Urgent care clinic** — evenings/weekends, non-life-threatening problems: bad flu, sprains, cuts needing stitches, infections. Far cheaper than an ER.
- 3 Emergency room (ER)** — genuine emergencies only: trouble breathing, chest pain, severe bleeding, head injuries, anything life-threatening. Call **911** for an ambulance. In a true emergency, go — do not price-shop your own life.
- 4 Nurse hotline** — many insurance plans and campus clinics run a 24/7 phone line to help you decide which of the above you need. Save the number now.

THREE HABITS THAT SAVE YOU REAL MONEY

1) Keep your insurance card photographed in your phone. 2) Ask "is this in-network?" before any non-emergency appointment. 3) If a bill looks wrong or impossible, don't ignore it and don't just pay it — call the billing office. Bills contain errors constantly, and payment plans or "financial assistance" exist if you ask.

Mental health counts too

Most universities include **free counseling sessions** in your fees — therapists who talk to homesick, stressed, overwhelmed students all day and are surprised by nothing. Using them is normal here; Chapter 19 covers this properly. For now, just know the resource exists and is already paid for.

PART III • LIVING SMART

Chapter 10 — Phones and staying connected

Your U.S. number is infrastructure. Get a cheap one fast, then optimize at leisure.

The fast, sensible path

- 1 **Before flying:** confirm your phone is carrier-unlocked (ask your home carrier). A locked phone in a new country is a paperweight with photos.
 - 2 **Day 1–2:** get a prepaid SIM or eSIM from a U.S. carrier or their budget brands. No contract, no SSN, activated in minutes. \$25–40/month typically buys plenty of data.
 - 3 **Month 2+:** once life stabilizes, compare student discounts, family-plan shares with friends, and budget carriers. Loyalty to your airport SIM is not required.
- **Keep your home number alive** if you can — many banks and services back home send verification codes to it. Roaming disabled, SIM stored safely, or moved to an eSIM slot.
 - **Wi-Fi calling + WhatsApp** handle family calls free. Teach the relatives before you leave; it's easier in person.

PART III • LIVING SMART

Chapter 11 — Getting around: transit, licenses, and cars

America's transport situation depends entirely on where you land. Campus towns are walkable; much of the country is built for cars.

Start with the free and cheap

- **Your student ID often includes transit** — many schools bundle free or discounted bus/metro passes, plus campus shuttles (including safe-ride evening shuttles). Ask at orientation.
- **Bikes** are the classic student solution. Buy used, budget for a solid lock, and learn local rules (helmets, lights at night).
- **Rideshare apps** fill the gaps — fine occasionally, budget-destroying as a lifestyle.

Driving

Rules vary by state: some let you drive on your home license or an International Driving Permit for a limited period; others want you to get a local license quickly. Check your state's DMV website. Getting the local license usually means a knowledge test and a road test — and it doubles as your everyday ID.

IF YOU BUY A CAR

The purchase price is the entry fee, not the cost. Insurance (expensive for new drivers with no U.S. history), registration, inspection, parking, fuel, and repairs are the real budget. Never buy a used car without a mechanic's inspection and a vehicle history report — and be suspicious of any seller who objects to either.

PART III · LIVING SMART

Chapter 12 — Groceries and the art of not going broke

Food is the budget line you control most. Small habits here fund your entire social life.

Know your store tiers

- **Budget and discount grocers** — where your staples should come from. Same eggs, smaller price.
- **Mainstream supermarkets** — fine, especially on sale items and store brands.
- **International and ethnic markets** — the secret weapon. Spices, rice, produce, and the tastes of home at a fraction of "international aisle" prices. Find yours in week one; it's good for your wallet *and* your soul.
- **Convenience stores and delivery apps** — emergencies only. Delivery fees, service fees, and tips can nearly double a meal's cost.

The six habits

- ☐ **Check the unit price** (the tiny price-per-ounce on the shelf tag) — it exposes fake bargains instantly.
- ☐ **Store brands over name brands** — often the same factory, 20–40% cheaper.
- ☐ **Get the free loyalty card** at your main store; sale prices often require it.
- ☐ **Cook in batches.** One Sunday pot of something from home = five weekday meals and one wave of homesickness cured.
- ☐ **Never shop hungry.** This is science.
- ☐ **Flash your student ID everywhere** — restaurants, software, transit, museums, phone plans. The discount exists more often than it's advertised; asking is free.

PART III · LIVING SMART

Chapter 13 — Winter is real: a survival briefing

If you're coming from somewhere warm to somewhere with actual winter, respect it. Cold is a solvable engineering problem.

- **Layers beat one big coat:** a base layer, a warm middle (fleece/wool), and a wind-and-waterproof shell. Cotton is a bad insulator when wet — wool and synthetics win.
- **The extremities rule:** hat, gloves, warm socks, and waterproof boots with grip do more than people expect. Most heat escapes where you didn't cover.
- **Buy winter gear in America** — end-of-season sales, outlet stores, and secondhand shops make quality coats affordable. Don't waste suitcase space bringing a coat that isn't up to the job.
- **Winter maintenance:** moisturizer and lip balm (indoor heating is desert-dry), vitamin D if your doctor suggests it, and light — short dark days affect mood, so get outside at midday and keep your routine.
- **Black ice** is invisible ice on pavement. Walk like a penguin — short, flat steps. Everyone falls once; make yours a small one.

PART IV · SCHOOL, WORK & THE RULES

Chapter 14 — American classroom culture, decoded

You can be brilliant and still stumble here, because the unwritten rules are different. Here they are, written.

The five biggest differences

- 1 **Participation is graded.** In many countries, silence is respect. Here, silence reads as absence. Speaking up — even questions, even imperfect English — is often literally part of your grade. Set a goal: one contribution per class. Nobody is grading your accent.
- 2 **The syllabus is a contract.** Every deadline, grading rule, and policy for the semester is in that document from day one. "I didn't know" is not a recognized defense. Read it; calendar every date.
- 3 **Office hours are an invitation, not a punishment.** Professors reserve hours specifically to talk to students, and mostly sit there alone. Going to office hours is how you get help, mentorship, and — later — recommendation letters. The students who go are not the weak ones; they're the smart ones.
- 4 **Continuous work beats final sprints.** Grades accumulate through homework, quizzes, projects, and midterms. You cannot save a semester in the last two weeks, and you can't destroy one with a single bad quiz. Steady wins.
- 5 **Professors are informal, not unserious.** Some go by first names, chat casually, joke in class. Match their friendliness — but don't confuse it with low standards. Emails still start with a greeting, state the course, and ask clearly.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY: THE UNTRANSLATABLE RULE

American universities treat plagiarism and unauthorized collaboration as major offenses — the kind with hearings, transcript marks, and consequences for your visa status if you're suspended. The standards may be stricter and differently defined than home: copying without citation, reusing your own past paper, sharing homework answers, or crossing a course's AI-use policy can all count. Every course states its rules; when unsure, ask the professor *before* submitting, and cite generously. Your writing center will help for free.

PART IV · SCHOOL, WORK & THE RULES

Chapter 15 — Working legally: on-campus, CPT, OPT & STEM OPT

You can work in America as an F-1 student — within specific lanes. Stay in the lanes; the shoulder of this road is a cliff.

The four lanes

Lane	The shape of it
On-campus work	Library, dining, research and teaching assistantships, campus offices. Generally up to 20 hours/week while school is in session (more during official breaks). Usually no special authorization beyond eligibility — but tell your DSO, and this is your SSN ticket (Ch. 7).
CPT (Curricular Practical Training)	Off-campus internships/co-ops that are part of your curriculum, <i>while studying</i> . Requires DSO authorization on your I-20 <i>before</i> you start — not after, not retroactively.
OPT (Optional Practical Training)	Usually 12 months of work authorization in your field, most commonly used after graduation. Requires applying months ahead through your DSO and USCIS — mind the application windows and don't work until approval is in hand.
STEM OPT extension	If your degree is on the government's STEM list, an extension of OPT (currently an additional 24 months) with extra employer requirements. Ask your DSO whether your program qualifies.

THE LINE YOU NEVER CROSS

Unauthorized work — off-the-books cash jobs, freelancing for clients, driving for delivery apps, monetized side hustles — can end your student status and future U.S. options entirely. It is the most expensive money an international student can earn. If any opportunity involves payment, ask your DSO *first*. "Everyone does it" is not a defense that has ever worked.

Making the lanes work for you

- Want an on-campus job? Apply in the first weeks — they go fast. Professors also hire graders and research assistants; asking after class works.
- Planning a summer internship? Talk to your DSO and career office in *fall*, so CPT paperwork never blocks an offer.
- Graduating? Put the OPT application timeline on your calendar months out. Late applications are the classic self-inflicted wound.

PART IV · SCHOOL, WORK & THE RULES

Chapter 16 — Taxes: yes, you — every year

Here's the sentence that surprises every international student: even with zero income, you have a tax filing obligation. Breathe. It's mostly forms.

What's actually required

- **Everyone on F-1 status files something** each spring for the previous calendar year — at minimum an informational form (Form 8843) confirming your student status, even with no income.
- **Earned money?** (on-campus job, authorized training, taxable scholarship) — you'll receive forms like a **W-2** from employers by late January, and you'll file a **nonresident tax return**. You may even get a refund; many students do.
- **Nonresident ≠ resident filing.** For your first years, F-1 students generally file as *nonresidents* — which means popular consumer tax software designed for residents is often the *wrong tool*. Filing the wrong form is a common, fixable, but annoying mistake.
- **Tax treaties** between the U.S. and many countries can reduce what you owe. The right software or advisor applies these automatically.

The easy path

- 1 Ask your international student office — most schools provide free access to nonresident tax software and run tax workshops every spring. This solves 90% of it.
- 2 Keep a "tax" folder: W-2s, scholarship letters, and any tax forms that arrive by mail or email each January–February.
- 3 File by the mid-April deadline. It usually takes an evening, not a lifetime.

THE IRS WILL NOT CALL YOU

Scammers phone international students pretending to be the IRS or immigration, claiming unpaid taxes and threatening arrest or deportation unless you pay immediately — by gift card, wire, or crypto. This is always, one hundred percent of the time, a scam. Real tax authorities send letters, never threaten arrest by phone, and have never once accepted iTunes cards as currency. Hang up and tell your friends.

Chapter 17 — Networking the American way

In many cultures, asking strangers for career help is presumptuous. In America, it's Tuesday. This is a system — learn to use it.

The mindset shift

American professional culture runs on **weak ties** — friendly, low-stakes professional connections. People genuinely expect students to reach out, ask questions, and request advice. It's not begging; it's how careers work here. The person who "knows someone" gets the interview, and you're allowed to become someone who knows someone.

The starter system

- 1 **Build a clean LinkedIn profile** in your first semester: professional-ish photo, clear headline (program + interests), your education and experience. Recruiters and alumni actually look.
- 2 **Use your career center early** — résumé reviews (U.S. résumé format differs from CVs at home: one page, no photo, no age), mock interviews, job boards. Free, underused, already paid for.
- 3 **Mine the alumni network.** Alumni from your school — especially those from your country or program — mostly respond warmly to polite messages. Ask for 20 minutes of advice, not a job. This is called an *informational interview*, and it's the most powerful underrated move in American careers.
- 4 **Show up:** career fairs, department talks, student clubs in your field. Half of networking is repeated presence until familiar faces become contacts.
- 5 **Follow up within a day or two** — a short thank-you message referencing something specific. This tiny habit separates you from almost everyone.

A MESSAGE TEMPLATE THAT WORKS

"Hi [Name], I'm a [program] student at [school] and I saw you work in [field] at [company]. I'm trying to learn how people build careers in this area — would you be open to a 20-minute call sometime? I'd really value your perspective." Short, specific, no job request. Send ten of these; two or three replies will change your trajectory.

Chapter 18 — Safety, scams, and emergencies

America is mostly safe and mostly kind. A few learned habits and a scam radar handle the rest.

The number: 911

911 is for all emergencies — police, fire, ambulance. Free from any phone, and dispatchers can access translators. Use it for genuine emergencies; for non-urgent police matters, cities have separate non-emergency lines. Also save: campus security (often faster than city police on campus and runs late-night safe-walk escorts), your country's nearest consulate, and one local friend.

Everyday safety habits

- Know your campus's emergency alert system and sign up for the texts.
- Share your location with a trusted friend when meeting strangers (marketplace deals, first dates) — and meet in public places.
- Headphones down and eyes up in unfamiliar areas at night; use campus safe-ride shuttles — that's what they're for.
- Renter's insurance costs a few dollars a month and replaces your laptop when bad luck visits. Worth it.

The scam radar

International students are specifically targeted, because scammers know you're new to the system. The big four:

The scam	The tell
"IRS/immigration" phone threats	Threats of arrest/deportation + demands for immediate payment via gift cards, wire, or crypto. Government agencies never do this. Hang up.
Rental scams	Below-market rent, can't view the unit, wire money to "hold" it. (Full checklist in Chapter 8.)
Job/check scams	"Personal assistant" jobs that overpay you by check and ask you to send back the difference. The check bounces later; your money is gone. Also: any "job" asking you to move money through your account is money laundering with your visa as the stake.
Phishing & "tech support"	Urgent emails/texts about your account, package, or SEVIS record with a link to "verify." Go to the real website yourself; never click, never share codes.

THE UNIVERSAL RULE

Urgency + secrecy + unusual payment method = scam. Every time. No legitimate institution demands gift cards, forbids you from telling anyone, or gives you ten minutes to decide. When pressure spikes, that's your signal to slow down and call your international office or bank directly.

PART V · THRIVING

Chapter 19 — Homesickness, culture shock, and your mind

The least discussed part of studying abroad is the emotional physics of it. Knowing the pattern is half the protection.

The curve everyone rides

Nearly every international student moves through the same arc: the **honeymoon** (everything is exciting), the **dip** (usually weeks 3–10: everything is annoying, home calls feel heavy, you question the whole decision), the **adjustment** (routines form, the city shrinks to human size), and finally **belonging**. The dip is not evidence you made a mistake. It's the documented, temporary, nearly universal cost of transplanting a life. It passes — faster with the habits below.

What actually helps

- **Build structure fast.** Regular sleep, real meals, a study rhythm, and movement. Mood follows routine more than the other way around.
- **One community, minimum.** Join one thing in month one — a club, a faith community, an intramural team, a country/culture association. Belonging is logistics before it's feelings.
- **Balance the two worlds.** Call home regularly — but not so constantly that you never land here. Cook the food from home; share it with new people. That's integration, not betrayal.
- **Say yes early.** The invitations of the first month set up the friendships of the first year. Tired is temporary; go anyway (within reason).
- **Sunlight and movement daily**, doubly so in winter (Chapter 13).

When it's more than homesickness

If weeks pass and you're still not sleeping, skipping classes, withdrawing from everyone, or feeling hopeless — that's not weakness and not a visa problem; it's a health matter with real help available. Your university's **counseling center** offers free, confidential sessions (already covered by your fees), and international student advisors have seen every version of this. In the U.S., seeking counseling is treated as routine self-maintenance, like going to the gym. If things ever feel like a crisis, the **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline** (call or text 988) is available 24/7. Reaching out early is what the strong ones do.

REAL TALK

One day — sooner than you think — a brand-new student will ask you where the international grocery store is, and you'll give directions without opening your phone. That's the moment you'll realize this place quietly became yours. Everything in this guide is just the bridge between today and that day.

APPENDIX

The acronym glossary

Term	Plain English
DSO	Designated School Official — your international office's immigration expert; your first call for any status question.
SEVIS	The government database tracking international students. Your I-901 fee funds it; your DSO updates it.
I-20	Certificate of eligibility issued by your school — the paper backbone of your F-1 status.
I-94	Your electronic arrival record showing class of admission (F-1) and permitted stay (D/S).
D/S	"Duration of status" — you may stay as long as you maintain valid student status.
CBP	Customs and Border Protection — the officers at the port of entry.
USCIS	The agency that processes immigration benefits like OPT applications.
CPT / OPT	Work authorizations: CPT for curricular internships during study; OPT typically for your field after graduation.
SSN / ITIN	Tax identification numbers — SSN if you're authorized to work; ITIN in some non-work tax situations.
W-2 / Form 8843	W-2: your employer's annual wage statement. 8843: the form every F-1 student files, income or not.
DMV / RMV	The state office for driver's licenses and state IDs (name varies by state).
In-network / copay / deductible	Insurance survival vocabulary — see Chapter 9.

Your bonuses

This kit includes two companion tools built to be used, not just read: the **First 30 Days in America Planner** (turn Part II into a week-by-week action plan with trackers) and the **Complete Packing Checklist** (what to bring, what to buy there, and what customs won't let through). Open the Planner the week you land.

Stay connected

Created by **Nii Obodai** — say hello, ask your questions, and tag me when you land. I read everything.

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